

Heretic from Abroad Faith on the Way



In that city, no one forbade asking questions.
They only taught them to wait.

Every question had its time, and every time had its room, and every room had a key hung high enough for children to see it and low enough for adults to pretend it was not a secret. The small questions stayed outside, near the benches, and were solved between prayer and prayer, between tea and a cookie, between someone who already knew and someone who still dared not to know. The great questions went inside.

The inner room stood at the end of the study hall, behind a wooden cabinet no one touched even after there was no longer anything in it. Its door was

narrower than the other doors, as if it had been built for people willing to bow before entering. Above it hung an old sign, in Hebrew only:

The Inner Room

Someone had once added an English translation for donors from abroad, but the translation was crooked, and no one had corrected it for years:

THE INNER ROOM — ANSWERS ONLY

Some in the city saw that as a joke.

Some saw it as precision.

Usually, when a difficult question arrived, they would put it in a brown envelope, close the door, and wait. Sometimes an hour. Sometimes a night. Once, three days. In the end, an answer would come out. Not always a happy answer. Not always one people understood. But an answer. And in that city, an answer was something you could place on a table, even if you could not place the heart on it.

Until the note arrived without an envelope.

It was found in the morning on the chair beside the door. It had no name, no date, no respectful opening, not even “To the honored rabbis,” not even “A question.” Only one sentence, in handwriting that did not hurry and did not apologize:

What do you do with someone who has returned, but has no way to enter?

That morning they did not open the room right away.

Rabbi Menachem Rosen stood before the note and read it three times. The first time as head of the study hall. The second time as a man who had already seen people return too late. The third time, he did not know as what.

Rabbi Elikim Barzel said, “We need to know who this is about.”

Naftali, the young student, said too quickly, “Maybe it is a general question.”

“There are no general questions,” Barzel said. “There are only people afraid to provide details.”

Rabbi Rosen did not lift his eyes from the note.

Outside, in the street, a man who did not know the city’s rules for questions was standing on a short ladder, trying to straighten the English sign.

His name was Yonah Winter, but by noon they were already calling him something else.

Yonah had arrived in the land two days earlier.

He did not say, “I have returned.” He did not say, “I came to visit,” either. Both words sounded too certain to him. At the airport, when the clerk asked how long he would be here, Yonah answered, “It depends,” and the clerk looked at him as if depends were a country not recognized by the system.

Outside waited a taxi driver named Samir. Yonah knew his name from the license hanging on the dashboard. Hebrew spoke on the radio, and from the phone lying beside the steering wheel someone answered in Arabic. Yonah sat in the back and looked through the window at sunlight falling on fences, warehouses, eucalyptus trees, exit signs, writing in three languages, and dry weeds that looked as if they knew the country better than anyone who traveled over it.

“You are from abroad?” Samir asked.

“Yes.”

“But you have Hebrew.”

“I do.”

“So you are from here.”

Yonah smiled. “It is more complicated.”

Samir laughed. “Here everything is more complicated. But even someone who says he is outside—the road recognizes him.”

Yonah did not answer. He looked at the light. There were things in the land that irritated him only because he had not yet stopped caring about them. Abroad, Hebrew had been for him a language of books, conversations, and family messages. Here it returned through an open window, through the smell of hot dust, through the shadow of a eucalyptus on a wall, without asking permission.

He loved the land. He did not know where to put that.

He came to the city with one suitcase and an address folded in his coat pocket. The coat was too light for the weather and too warm for the season, the kind a person wears not because it fits but because it was already on him when he decided not to turn back from the journey. He had come for a small apartment belonging to a distant uncle, or for a document that had to be translated, or for an inheritance matter not worth the price of the flight and yet still strong enough to bring him.

He was Jewish; there was no doubt about that.

Even if there were people in the city who worked hard to arrange the doubt in its proper place.

He was not formerly religious. There was no drama of departure in him, no rabbi who had angered him in his youth, no yeshiva he had left in the middle of the night. He grew up in a gently traditional home: Kiddush when the family was together, matzah on Passover, candles sometimes, synagogue on Yom Kippur if it did not rain and if there had not been an argument beforehand. In his home, commandments were not kept the way one guards a border, and they were not broken the way one rebels against a king. The things were simply there: challah, grandfather, songs, laughter, a television murmuring low, someone saying “come on, honor it” before a blessing not everyone listened to.

Yonah had never left religion because he had never entered it all the way. But he had also never left Judaism.

It remained in him like a language in which one can dream, even after years of speaking differently by day.

His Hebrew was too good for a tourist and too distant for a local. He knew when people said Maariv and when they said Arvit, but he did not always remember on which bench one could sit without someone shifting their eyes. He knew verses the way one knows streets in a city one left long ago: enough to arrive, not enough to pretend he lived there. Sometimes he would quote half a sentence and then fall silent, as if the other half belonged to someone else.

People asked him quiet questions, the way one asks someone when one does not know whether he is one of us or someone to be careful around.

“Are you from here?”

“Not exactly.”

“But you have Hebrew.”

“A little.”

“People don’t speak like that with a little.”

“Then maybe more than a little.”

“Did you study?”

“What?”

“You know.”

“All kinds of things.”

“Yeshiva?”

“No.”

“So where?”

Yonah would smile. “People.”

It was an answer that satisfied no one, and therefore it quickly repeated itself. In that city, anything that did not fit a category became a story before it had time to be a person.

They did not call him an apikores, at least not at first. The word was too heavy. “Heretic” was lighter. Shorter. Better suited to stairs, to courtyards, to children, to a synagogue attendant sighing when he sees a man without a kippah standing too close to the bookcase.

But that was not accurate either.

Yonah did not like fighting faith. He did not make rituals out of his secularity. He did not look for ways to refute. He was open to conversation with everyone in a way that irritated nearly every side: with rabbis and atheists, with believers and with people who had lost belief, with those who spoke in the name of tradition and those who spoke in the name of science, with those who knew how to quote and those who knew only how to hurt.

He did not think every opinion was true. He only wanted to know what it was protecting.

He held no organized system. He had no beautiful names for what he thought. But he had a habit: before accepting an answer as an answer, he would ask what question had been run over on the way to it. Before trusting a boundary, he would check whether it was still guarding something alive, or only defending itself.

He had not learned that in a study hall. Perhaps he had learned it in train stations, in unfinished languages, in waiting rooms, in people who spoke of home as if it were a place one could reach only after someone else agreed to call it that.

They knew more than he did about almost everything. Sometimes, precisely because of that, they did not see when knowledge began to become a wall.

The name stuck to him because of the clock.

The clock above the entrance to the study hall had been three minutes slow since the month of Av in a year no one any longer agreed to remember exactly. Some said it began after a power outage. Some said one of the attendants had moved it on purpose so evening prayer would not start too early. Some said, quietly, that time in the study hall had always moved a little differently.

Yonah asked where the ladder was, climbed up, opened the little box at the back, turned something, climbed down, and the clock began to keep time.

“A magician,” one of the children said.

“Not a magician,” Yonah said. “A battery.”

The child thought for a moment and said, “Then a heretic.”

Yonah looked at him. “That is usually not the same profession.”

“Here it is,” the child said.

By evening, some were already calling him the heretic from a foreign land. Not to his face at first. Later, yes. In that city, even nicknames had to pass through several people before they became permitted.

Yonah did not argue with the name. He did not accept it, but he did not reject it either. Some names, if you fight them, only learn the shape of your hand. He let it pass beside him like a wet cat in a courtyard. Sometimes, when someone called him that from across the street, he would answer “Yes?” as if it were a spelling mistake one could live with.

On the morning the note was found, Yonah was standing on the ladder trying to understand why the English letters above the inner room leaned slightly to the left. Not the whole sign. Only the word ANSWERS. It looked as if it were moving away from the door.

“Don’t touch that,” said the attendant.

“Why?”

“It is a sign.”

“I know.”

“Then don’t touch it.”

“It’s crooked.”

“It has always been crooked.”

Yonah closed the screwdriver. “That is not as strong an argument as you think.”

The attendant did not laugh, but the child from the clock laughed for him.

Inside, the rabbis were still standing before the note.

After a few minutes, they entered the inner room: Rabbi Menachem Rosen, Rabbi Elikim Barzel, Shmuel Hochman, and Naftali. They closed the door. Those outside heard the handle descend quietly, as if the door itself asked them not to exaggerate its meaning.

In the room there was a long table, four chairs, and one additional chair no one used. The fifth chair always stood by the wall, lightly covered with dust. No one knew exactly for whom it was intended. Some said for an important guest. Some said for Elijah. Some said the chair remained from the days when they still invited inside the person about whom the question was being asked. No one moved it.

Rabbi Rosen placed the note in the center of the table, as if, if it were far enough from everyone, it would stop belonging to someone.

Rabbi Barzel read aloud:

“What do you do with someone who has returned, but has no way to enter?”

He did not read it like a question. He read it like a door someone had tried to open without permission.

“Returned from where?” he asked.

Shmuel Hochman said, "That is exactly what is not written."

"Then there is no question," Barzel said. "There is a hint."

Naftali said, "Maybe the hint is the question."

Barzel looked at him until Naftali lowered his eyes.

Rabbi Rosen sat down slowly. His movements were those of a man who had learned not to hurry near words. He was the kind of person whose silence is not empty but too full, and therefore others rush to fill it.

"Let us suppose it is a person who has returned to the community," he said.

"If he left willingly," Barzel said, "return does not erase departure."

"And if he left because no place was left for him?" Hochman asked.

"Someone for whom no place was left usually knows how to say who pushed him out."

"Not always," Rabbi Rosen said.

They were silent.

Outside, a small metallic sound was heard, as if someone were trying to fit a key into a lock not his own.

Naftali took a sheet of paper and began listing possibilities. His handwriting was quick, too precise, the handwriting of someone who believes that if he writes fast enough, thought will not have time to escape.

A penitent.

An excommunicated man.

A convert.

A son who returned.

A woman who returned.

A person who sinned.

A person rejected by mistake.

A person rejected rightly.

A person with no documents.

A person with documents and no face.

At that point he stopped. He had not meant to write the last words. They came out of the pen before he managed to ask whether they were allowed.

Barzel saw.

“There is no such category,” he said.

Naftali erased quickly. The erasure looked worse than the writing.

Hochman paced the room. He disliked discussions that did not have the shape of a solution. As head of the community, he knew what happens to a question left too long without an answer: it begins to walk among people. At first quietly. Then near doors. Then in names. In the end it is no longer a question but a camp.

Once, years before, a single rumor had closed an entire family inside its house. No one remembered afterward who had said it first; everyone remembered who stopped coming.

“We need to know if it is urgent,” he said.

“A question without a name is always urgent to the one who wrote it,” Rabbi Rosen said.

“Or to the one who wants to force us to answer without details,” Barzel said.

“That too can be.”

“Then why treat it seriously?”

“Because even manipulation sometimes uses a real question.”

Barzel leaned back. “With respect, Rabbi, if we open every question that has no name, we will close no door.”

“Maybe that is precisely the question,” Naftali said, almost without voice.

This time Barzel did not look at him. Perhaps because he had heard, and perhaps because he did not want to.

The discussion continued.

They brought books. Not many at first. Then more. The table, wide enough for four men and one question, became too narrow for sources. Pages opened, closed, bookmarks moved from place to place. One word gave birth to another. “Returned” opened into “repentance,” “repentance” into “regret,” “regret” into “acceptance for the future,” “way” into “entrance,” “enter” into “congregation,” “congregation” into “assembly,” “assembly” into “boundary.”

Every word was right. Every path led. No path arrived.

Toward noon Hochman left the room to ask for tea. Outside he found Yonah sitting on the bench, holding the English sign on his knees. Beside him stood the child from the clock, holding screws in an open palm, like someone holding seeds for a bird.

Across the street from the study hall, the owner of a small cafe was lowering plastic chairs onto the sidewalk. His name was Nasser, and everyone called him Nasser even when they bought from him without admitting they bought from him. He sold black coffee, cigarettes, cold water, and pita with za’atar that was not written on any menu. Yonah had bought from him that morning. Nasser asked where he was from. Yonah said, “Outside.” Nasser said, “That is not a place, but here it is enough of an address.”

“What are you doing?” Hochman asked.

“Trying to understand whether the problem is in the sign or in the translation.”

“The sign is fine.”

“The sign is stable. That is not the same thing.”

Hochman was too tired to argue with a man from outside about the difference between stable and fine.

“Put it back the way it was,” he said.

“The way it was is exactly what made me take it down.”

“This is not the time.”

“Time is also something I fixed for you today.”

The child laughed again. Hochman did not.

From the room came Barzel’s voice, heavy and cutting. Hochman turned to go, but Yonah asked:

“Why does it say in English ‘Answers only’?”

Hochman stopped.

“What?”

“On the room. In Hebrew it says ‘The inner room.’ In English it says ‘Answers only.’ That is not the same thing.”

“It is for people from abroad.”

“People from abroad don’t need to know that it is inner?”

“They need to understand that it is a place of answers.”

Yonah ran a finger over the letters. “Maybe that is the problem.”

Hochman looked at him.

Yonah lifted the sign slightly, as if weighing it. “A place that thinks it is only for answers begins to get confused when the question does not behave nicely.”

“You don’t know what we’re talking about.”

“Correct,” Yonah said.

It was an answer Hochman did not know what to do with.

Nasser, from the other side of the road, said in a completely ordinary voice:
“Sometimes the problem is not in the key. The doorframe has shifted.”

Hochman looked at him. Nasser shrugged.

“I’m talking about doors,” he said. “Not about you.”

Yonah smiled, but not too much.

Hochman took the tea and went back inside.

Inside, Rabbi Rosen stood by the window. The curtain was stuck in its track, so light entered only partly, a narrow line across the table. The note lay inside that line.

“He asked about the sign,” Hochman said.

“Who?” Barzel asked.

“The heretic from a foreign land.”

Naftali lifted his head.

Rabbi Rosen did not turn around. “What did he ask?”

“Why the English says it is a room of answers only.”

Barzel said, “Because that is what it is.”

“No,” Rabbi Rosen said.

Everyone looked at him.

He touched the stuck curtain and failed to move it. “That is what we want to come out of it.”

The silence afterward was not agreement. But it was new.

Barzel closed a book. “Rabbi, we are not going to start learning from the translation of some sign.”

“No,” Rabbi Rosen said. “Not from the sign.”

Naftali looked at the note. "But maybe from the mistake."

"Even mistakes," Barzel said, "need a boundary."

"True," Rabbi Rosen said. "But sometimes the boundary they reveal is not theirs."

Hochman felt the discussion moving toward a place that could not be presented to the public. He hated such places. Not because they were false, but because they were too true before they were useful.

"In the end we need to answer," he said.

"Yes," Rabbi Rosen said. "But perhaps first we need to know to whom."

"To the one who returned," Barzel said.

Rabbi Rosen looked at him. "Or to the one who did not open."

The sentence remained in the room. It touched no book. It asked for no source. That made it harder to move.

Toward evening the people outside began to ask whether an answer had come out. The attendant said no. Then he said "not yet." Then he stopped answering. In the study hall, rumors began to move among the benches like cats who know where the milk was placed.

"It's about Weiss's son," someone said.

"Which son?"

"The one no one talks about."

"So why now?"

"Maybe he came back."

"They didn't let him in?"

"Who said he wanted to?"

“So why the question?”

“You’re asking me?”

A woman standing in the women’s section heard and said quietly, “Maybe it is about Dayan’s Rivka.”

“She didn’t return,” they told her.

“Did anyone ask her?”

After that the silence came down quickly, like a blanket thrown over something broken.

Yonah heard fragments. Not everything. He did not ask. There are places where a man from outside learns too quickly that any question of his will sound like an investigation. He kept working on the sign, but did not put it back. In the street someone asked a price, someone answered in Arabic, a child shouted in Hebrew, and one tourist asked for a stop in English. Then he placed the sign by the wall, under the window, so that anyone who passed could see the words:

ANSWERS ONLY

without the door that explained them.

Naftali came out of the room toward sunset. His face was a little pale. He was not used to thinking that did not progress through sources. He was used to climbing: verse, Mishnah, Talmud, early authorities, later authorities, response, custom, act. Here every ladder brought him to the same door.

Yonah was still sitting on the bench.

“Are you really a heretic?” Naftali asked.

Yonah looked at him as if he had asked whether he was really left-handed.

“Depends who is asking.”

“I am.”

“Then not enough for you.”

Naftali did not know whether that was an answer or mercy.

He sat at the edge of the bench, not too close. “Why did you stay?”

“I’m waiting to be paid.”

“For the sign?”

“For the clock, the sign, and another lock someone promised to bring and did not.”

“That is not much.”

“That is why I’m not in a hurry.”

Naftali was silent. Then he said:

“There are things you don’t understand.”

“Of course.”

“No, I mean really. It has weight. You can’t open everything because of a beautiful sentence.”

“I don’t know beautiful sentences.”

“You do.”

“Not on purpose.”

Naftali smiled despite himself.

Yonah looked at the door of the inner room. “What is the question?”

Naftali tensed. “I can’t say.”

“Then why did you come out?”

It was too simple a question. Naftali felt it like a small stone inside a shoe.

“I don’t know.”

“That is also something.”

“Not with us.”

“With you, probably especially.”

Naftali almost stood up, but stayed. “If a person leaves, it has meaning. If he returns, it has meaning. One cannot ignore what happened.”

“Who said ignore?”

“So what are you saying?”

“I’m not saying. I don’t know who this is about.”

“Then how can you think you have anything to say?”

Yonah looked at him. Not severely. Almost wearily.

“Because sometimes you can know where a sentence is stuck even without knowing the whole story.”

Naftali did not answer.

“You think the question is stuck in the one who returned,” Yonah said. “Maybe it is stuck in the way.”

Naftali looked at the door.

Yonah added, “Or in the one holding the key.”

“Sometimes,” Naftali said, “the key belongs to the one who was hurt.”

Yonah looked at him. That stopped him.

“True,” he said after a moment.

“And that you do not see from outside.”

Yonah set the cup on the floor. “Probably not enough.”

Naftali looked at the cup on the floor and said nothing.

At that moment the door opened. Rabbi Barzel stood in the doorway. He saw Naftali beside Yonah, and Yonah beside the sign, and the sign on the ground, and there was a shape to all of it he did not like.

“Naftali,” he said.

Naftali stood at once.

“And the sign?” Barzel asked.

Yonah lifted it. “I’m working on it.”

“Put it back.”

“As it was?”

“As it was.”

Yonah nodded. “That is usually what people ask me when they do not want a repair.”

Barzel looked at him. “Do you know what the problem is with people from outside?”

“They are cheaper?”

The child from the clock, who had appeared from who knows where, laughed aloud.

Barzel did not smile. “They think every closed door is fear.”

Yonah stood up, the sign in his hand. “No. Only a door no one remembers why they closed.”

“And sometimes,” Barzel said, “a closed door is the only thing left to someone who was once broken into. Sometimes the one who returns asks for a way to enter, but does not ask the person who must move again to make room for him. Sometimes mercy for the one who returns is cruelty toward the one who stayed.”

The sign became heavy in Yonah’s hand.

He did not find an answer right away. Good that he did not.

“That is true,” he said at last.

Barzel was a little surprised, but did not let it show.

“Then be careful,” he said. “Not every threshold is an invitation.”

Yonah lowered his eyes to the screwdriver. “And not every lock is justice.”

For a moment it seemed Barzel would say something that would close the entire street. But Rabbi Rosen called from inside:

“Elikim.”

Barzel did not lower his eyes from Yonah.

“Inside,” he said.

Naftali went in after him.

The door closed. Not all the way. Maybe because the lock was old. Maybe because someone had not pulled hard enough. Maybe because there are moments when even wood grows tired of its role.

Yonah remained outside with the sign.

He thought of putting it back the way it had been.

Then he thought not to.

Then he did a third thing: he screwed it back, but did not tighten it all the way.

Inside, the discussion approached the place where discussions become dangerous. Each person already understood what the others thought, and no one wanted to be the first to say it in a form that could not be taken back.

Barzel said, "If the person has returned, he must come. Give a name. Detail what happened. Accept conditions. There is no entry without accepting a way."

Hochman said, "And if his very arrival causes a rupture?"

"Then the rupture exists already."

"Now it is quiet."

"Quiet is not peace."

"And not every truth needs to be public."

"And not every fear is called responsibility."

Rabbi Rosen raised a hand. Not high. Enough.

Naftali said, "Maybe 'a way to enter' does not mean conditions. Maybe it means language."

"Language?" Barzel asked.

"Yes. Maybe he has no way to say he returned so that people will hear him as returning."

"If he truly returned, he will say it."

"And if everything he says will be heard through what he did when he left?"

The sentence was bigger than he was. He knew it the moment he said it. But it was already in the room.

Rabbi Rosen looked at him for a long time. "Who told you that?"

Naftali opened his mouth. Closed it.

"He didn't say it," he said. "I think I heard it."

Barzel said, "Outside one hears many things."

"Sometimes," Rabbi Rosen said, "that is our problem. That we do not."

Hochman went to the door. "Maybe we should bring him in."

"Whom?" Barzel asked.

"Winter."

"No."

"He is already part of the discussion."

"He is part of the noise."

"Elikim," Rabbi Rosen said, "he will not rule."

"Of course not."

"Then what are you afraid of?"

Barzel stood. His chair scraped backward with a harsh sound. "I am afraid of the day we no longer remember the difference between one who asks because he is bound, and one who asks because he has nothing to lose."

Rabbi Rosen did not answer immediately.

"That too is a true fear," he said at last.

Barzel was surprised. The softest thing one could say to him was to recognize that his fear was not foolishness.

"But," Rabbi Rosen continued, "there is another fear. The fear that one day we will protect the room so well that we will no longer notice that no one can enter it without first becoming a question."

Hochman looked for a moment toward the benches outside, as if counting who might disappear from them tomorrow.

Then he opened the door.

Yonah was there, standing on the ladder, holding a screw between his lips. He looked less like a heretic and more like a man trying not to drop something on someone else's head.

Hochman said, "Rabbi Menachem asks that you come in."

Yonah climbed down one step. Then another.

"Why?"

"Because you are already speaking."

"I'm not."

"Then maybe because of that."

Yonah took the screw from his mouth. "I am not a rabbi."

"That is known."

"And I do not believe what you need me to believe."

"That is going around the city too."

"So why?"

Hochman looked at him, and for the first time that day he seemed not like a community leader but like a man who would prefer someone else carry the hot bowl.

"Because sometimes one needs to hear how a sentence sounds without all the books around it."

Yonah looked into the room. Four men, a table, a note, open books, one chair by the wall. He did not enter.

"Can I stand here?" he asked.

"What?" Hochman said.

"Can I stand here?"

Rabbi Rosen heard. "Yes."

Yonah remained on the threshold.

Rabbi Rosen lifted the note. "Read."

Yonah read.

Slowly, but not because it was difficult. He read like a person checking whether the words had been placed correctly.

What do you do with someone who has returned, but has no way to enter?

He returned the note to the table.

"Well?" Barzel said.

"It does not ask what you think."

"And what do we think?"

"That there is a person outside, and you need to decide whether he has a way in."

"That is the question."

"Not sure."

Barzel smiled without joy. "Then what is the question, according to your method?"

Yonah looked at the door. Then at the dust-covered chair by the wall. Then at the sign that had returned to its place, still a little loose.

"I do not know a method," he said. "But from outside it sounds different."

"How?"

"As if someone has returned, but the way does not know how to be a way."

Naftali closed his eyes.

Barzel said, "A way does not know. People know."

"Then the people do not know how to be a way."

Silence.

The sentence stayed.

Rabbi Rosen said, "Continue."

Yonah ran a hand over the doorframe, as if he were not sure he was allowed to touch it. "You are asking what to do with someone who returned. But maybe he has already done his part. Maybe he returned. Maybe now the question is what to do with a place that is still built as if he has not."

"That is homily," Barzel said.

"Maybe," Yonah said. "I told you I do not know the profession."

"And what if the place is right?" Barzel asked. "What if there is a reason there is no way?"

"Then say there is no way."

"Sometimes that is the answer."

"Yes. But then do not call it 'what do we do with someone who has returned.' Call it 'how do we tell someone who returned that the door is still afraid of him.'"

Hochman took a short breath. Naftali looked at the table. Rabbi Rosen did not move.

"There are justified fears," Barzel said.

"There are," Yonah said.

"There are people whose return is dangerous."

"There are."

“There is damage that does not disappear.”

“Of course.”

“There are people who ask to enter not because they have changed, but because they are tired of being outside.”

Yonah was silent.

“That also exists,” he said.

Barzel looked at him, as if searching for the place where Yonah would flee into a beautiful sentence. Yonah did not flee.

“So what have you added?” Barzel asked.

“Nothing,” Yonah said at last. “Maybe only that if the door is closed out of fear, one should say fear. If it is closed by law, one should say law. If it is closed to protect someone who was hurt, one should say the name of the one being protected, even if not aloud. And if it is closed because you have forgotten how to open it, that is already a fourth thing.”

Rabbi Rosen lowered his eyes.

Barzel said, “And you know how to distinguish?”

“Not always.”

“Then why should we listen to you?”

Yonah smiled a little, not in victory. “Because I say I do not always know.”

That sentence angered Barzel more than he expected. Not because it was profound, but because it was hard to use against him. People who know too well where they stand are easier to move: you push from the right side. A person who is willing to leave room for not-knowing gives no good point of leverage.

“Not-knowing is not a virtue,” Barzel said.

“Correct.”

“Nor is doubt wisdom.”

“Correct.”

“So?”

“But knowledge that is afraid of doubt sometimes stops being knowledge. It becomes guarding.”

Barzel was silent.

Not because he was convinced.

Because the sentence had passed too close to something he knew.

Rabbi Rosen stood. He went to the dusty chair by the wall and placed a hand on it. Dust clung to his fingers. He looked at them as if they had said something he had not meant to say.

“Once,” he said, “we used to bring in here the person about whom the question was being asked.”

Hochman looked at him quickly. “That was many years ago.”

“Yes.”

“And it was stopped for a reason.”

“Probably.”

“Not probably. For a reason.”

Rabbi Rosen nodded. “Questions began to behave like people. People began to behave like evidence. It became difficult.”

“And therefore?” Barzel asked.

“And therefore we removed the person to save the question.”

Yonah said nothing.

“And perhaps,” Rabbi Rosen continued, “on the way we saved the question from the person until no person was left in it.”

Naftali lifted his eyes. It was the kind of sentence that, when a rabbi says it, becomes permitted only after it has already been said.

Barzel said, “What do you propose?”

Rabbi Rosen looked at the note. “Not an answer yet.”

“Then what?”

“To find the one who asked.”

Hochman almost said that was impossible. Then he remembered how many times in this city “impossible” had been another name for “unpleasant.”

“And if we do not find him?” he asked.

“Then we will find the door.”

Barzel did not like that. “A door is not a subject for a halakhic discussion.”

Yonah, who had almost already left, said, “Neither is a sign.”

Barzel looked at him.

“And still,” Yonah said, “sometimes it says more about the place than the place wants.”

This time the child did not laugh. He was standing outside, near the threshold. No one drove him away.

Evening descended slowly. People scattered and returned. Rumors changed shape. Someone brought dry cakes. Someone else said it was not nice to eat while a question was open. Someone answered that in this city people eat beside the dead and beside babies, so beside a question they can.

Toward night the four came out of the room. Yonah was no longer there. The sign hung in its place, but something in it had changed. Not the words. Not yet.

Only the tilt. ANSWERS no longer fled from the door. It stood straight, and that made the translation look even more wrong.

Rabbi Rosen stood before it for a long time.

“Take it down tomorrow,” he said.

“The sign?” asked the attendant.

“The English.”

The attendant grew anxious. “But the donors.”

“We will put different English.”

“What should it say?”

Rabbi Rosen did not answer.

Naftali, standing behind him, said quietly:

“Questions may enter.”

Rabbi Rosen looked at him.

Naftali blushed. “Or something like that.”

Rabbi Barzel, who was already on his way out, stopped. “That is not a translation.”

“True,” Rabbi Rosen said.

“So?”

“The previous one was not either.”

Barzel wanted to say something more, but the fatigue of the day rested on his shoulders like a wet tallit. He left.

The next morning, the city discovered two things.

The first: the inner room had not been abolished.

The second: the dusty chair no longer stood by the wall.

It had been placed beside the door, not inside and not outside. Exactly on the threshold. The attendant claimed it was temporary, because it needed cleaning. The child from the clock said that is always what people say about things they are afraid are permanent.

At noon they found Yonah at the station. His suitcase beside him, his coat on his knee. He was reading a book in English and stopped every few lines to look at the road, as if the bus were a possibility and not a promise.

Nasser was there with a thermos of coffee and small cups. He had no stand at the station, but everyone knew that if you stood there long enough, he appeared. He gave Yonah coffee without asking whether he wanted it.

“You’re leaving?” he asked.

“Probably.”

“People say that when they want someone to stop them.”

“Are you stopping me?”

“I sell coffee.”

Yonah laughed.

Nasser looked at the road. “Do you love the place?”

Yonah did not expect the question. “Which place?”

Nasser looked at him.

“Yes,” Yonah said. “But I am not always good at it.”

“So do not make it good,” Nasser said. “Take coffee.”

Yonah held the cup in both hands. The coffee was bitter and hot. At the station, Hebrew, Arabic, English, and Russian passed by, not as a festive mixture and

not as an argument, but the way people pass when they have somewhere to get to. The land was there without explaining itself.

Naftali arrived first. Then Rabbi Rosen. Hochman remained at a slight distance, because community leaders do not run after heretics at bus stations unless there is a public reason.

“You are leaving?” Naftali asked.

“That is what people say about people at stations.”

“Where to?”

“Outside.”

Naftali smiled. “That is a big place.”

“That is why there is room in it.”

Rabbi Rosen came closer. In his hand he held the note. Not the original. A copy, perhaps. Or perhaps the original. Yonah did not ask.

“We did not find who wrote it,” the rabbi said.

“Maybe good.”

“Why?”

“Because then you would go back to talking about him.”

Rabbi Rosen accepted this in silence.

“We will try differently,” he said at last.

“What does that mean?”

“I do not yet know.”

Yonah closed the book. “Not a bad beginning.”

“Do you believe in that?” the rabbi asked.

“In what?”

“In not knowing.”

Yonah thought a moment. “No. I do not believe in not knowing. I believe one should not hurry to lie in the name of knowing.”

Rabbi Rosen smiled. Not much. A small smile of a man who found a formulation he would not use in a sermon, but would keep for himself.

“And you?” Yonah asked.

“I believe in knowledge,” the rabbi said.

“That is dangerous.”

“Yes.”

“And still?”

“Yes.”

Yonah nodded. “Then perhaps we are not as far apart as it looks.”

The bus appeared at the end of the street. Like everything that comes from outside, it raised dust before it arrived.

Rabbi Rosen said, “They call you the heretic from a foreign land.”

“I heard.”

“It is not accurate.”

“Good nicknames are never accurate. They only reveal what frightens the person who gave them.”

Rabbi Rosen looked at him. “And what frightens us?”

Yonah stood, lifted the suitcase. “That one can know a great deal and still not hear.”

The bus stopped.

Naftali wanted to ask something, but the question could not find a way into his mouth in time. Yonah handed him the book.

“Take it.”

“What is it?”

“Not a holy book.”

“I understood that.”

“Not the opposite either.”

Naftali looked at the cover. He did not recognize it.

“So what is it?”

“A conversation.”

Naftali took it.

Yonah boarded the bus. Before the door he turned to Rabbi Rosen.

“The sign,” he said, “is still not a good translation.”

“I know.”

“Leave it a little not-good.”

“Why?”

“So you will have something to hear.”

The door closed. The bus drove away.

In the city, that afternoon, they hung a new sign above the inner room.

In Hebrew it still said:

The Inner Room

In English they wrote:

THE INNER ROOM — QUESTIONS MAY ENTER

Rabbi Barzel said it was too weak. Questions do not enter by themselves.

Rabbi Rosen said that was precisely why the word MAY was important.

Hochman said donors from abroad would understand. Naftali said maybe people from inside would too.

Nasser, passing by with a crate of cups, looked at the sign and said to the attendant:

“You are not writing Arabic?”

The attendant was confused. “Why?”

Nasser lifted a shoulder. “I don’t know. There is a door. Maybe one day someone will read.”

He kept walking before anyone could decide whether it was a comment, a joke, or only a sentence.

No one said the sign solved the question.

The question was still not solved.

They did not find the writer.

They did not know who had returned.

They did not know if he really had a way.

They did not know if the way should open.

They did not know if the door was afraid justly.

But that evening, before they locked the study hall, the attendant noticed the chair on the threshold.

“Bring it in?” he asked.

Rabbi Rosen stood by the door.

“No.”

“Take it out?”

Rabbi Rosen looked at the chair, then at the room, then at the street that had already grown dark.

“No.”

The attendant scratched his forehead. “So where is it?”

Rabbi Rosen said:

“For now.”

In that city, that was not an answer.

But it was a way not to close the question too quickly.